

and home inspector can help you decide whether you should have a radon test performed.

- **Asbestos.** From the 1950s through the 1970s, asbestos was used in buildings because of its excellent insulation properties. Since then, asbestos has been proved to cause lung cancer, asbestosis, and mesothelioma. It was banned from use in the late 1970s—but builders were allowed to use up their remaining supplies even after this date, so homes built into the 1980s can still contain this toxic material. (Whose brilliant idea was that?) The presence of asbestos is not an automatic deal breaker, since it can be remediated or encapsulated.
- **Roof damage.** Your inspector will call out even the smallest of dings on the roof, so you shouldn't be needlessly alarmed. However, if there are any leaks or major issues, you should proceed with caution. A typical asphalt shingle roof will last twenty-five to fifty years, and a replacement starts at \$8,000 but can go up to \$20,000 or more. (However, you may be able to negotiate with the seller to cover this cost through their home insurance. Talk with your agent about this option.)
- **Termites.** These wood-eating insects can cause significant damage to a property, essentially turning solid wood into a spongy mess. Though fixing termite damage is a big-ticket item, not everyone needs to be concerned. Termites are area-specific, so they may be less prevalent in some parts of the country. Here in Colorado, we see very few termites, so this is not part of our normal inspection process.
- **Lead paint.** Back in the day, lead was added to paint to help it dry quickly and resist moisture. What a brilliant, time-saving invention! Now we know that ingesting or inhaling even the smallest amount of lead paint can cause serious health problems. If built before 1978, your home is probably going to have lead paint somewhere inside, but it is likely covered up by multiple layers of non-lead paint. If this is the case, you should be concerned only if you're planning on disturbing the layers of paint by sanding or cutting into the walls.
- **HVAC.** This is a fancy acronym for heating, ventilation, and air-conditioning, so it includes your furnace, AC system, and the ducts